A bot that cannot verify is an expensive clicker.

The three stages I require before trusting any browser or system automation.

10 slides · swipe

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

The action was real. The result was imaginary.

I have watched agents celebrate completion after driving a browser to the exact place where nothing happened.

The click was real.
The change was not.

Every automation, three stages.

01 Observe the current state

02 Choose one specific action

03 Verify the transition happened

Python automates stage two. The system must automate stage three.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

A success check that actually proves something.

01 Target entity existed before I acted

02 The response matches the expected shape

03 A reload shows the persisted value, not the toast

04 The backend records the change under the right ID

05 A re-run does not duplicate the side effect

If the check can't fail, it can't pass either.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

The two halves of real automation.

MOTION

Doing the thing

clicks
types
or opens pages

CONTRACT

Proving the thing

state changed
persisted
id returned

Everyone builds the first half. Few build the second.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

Failure should be legible, not logged.

```
$ agent run invoice-approve

expected: status=approved for inv_8842

found: status=pending for inv_8842

exit 1  ← never silently 'done'
```

A confident log line is not a success condition.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

Where it actually breaks.

Duplicates. Partial success. A timeout that replayed the whole task. A stale session that made the page lie politely.

Every failure mode you didn't model is one the on-call will.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

The honest question to ask your bot.

What would make you stop and ask a human?

If the answer is 'nothing', it isn't an agent — it's a script with ambition.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

AUTOMATION · THE MINIMUM · 9/10

Before you ship one more automation.

01 Named success condition, written down

02 A verify step that can actually fail

03 A timeout that does NOT re-fire the action

04 A log a human can reconstruct the run from

05 An escape hatch when the input is weird

Ship with those five or ship a rumor.

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend

AUTOMATION · KEEP THIS · 10/10

Save this for the next automation review.

Most automation failures are success claims without evidence. Ask for the evidence, or don't grant the autonomy.

Save for later review

Anton Petnitsky · Python / agents / backend